

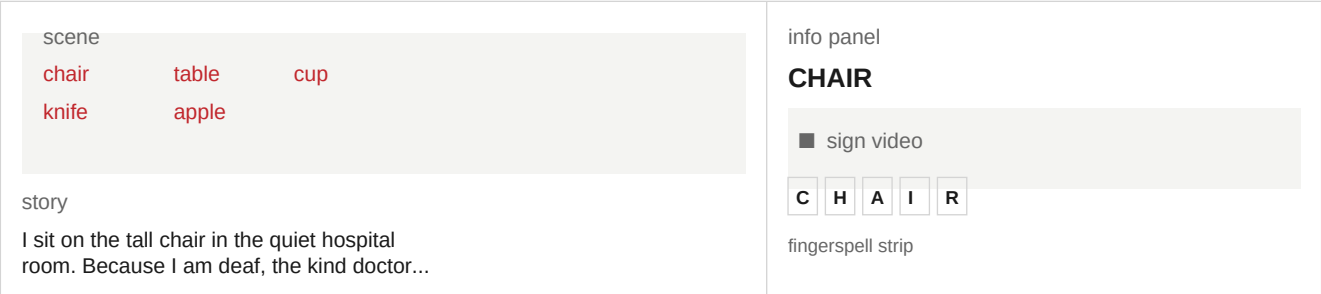
THE LEARNER PROFILE

Adults who lose their hearing post-lingually and are also non-native English speakers, learning English and a sign language in parallel. Their first language (e.g. Mandarin) is no longer accessible via hearing; their second language (English, partially intact through reading) becomes the bridge to acquiring a third (ASL). I am the user: a Monash MDS student, native Mandarin, completely deaf since 2025, learning ASL alongside English.

Existing sign-learning software targets Deaf-of-Deaf children (VL2 Storybook, Gallaudet) or hearing L2 ASL learners (Lifeprint, SignSchool). The late-deafened adult ESL profile sits outside both — and is the population most affected by isolation and high interaction friction in mainstream institutions.

WHAT THE TOOL DOES

A single-screen web app. Left column: a scene (interactive SVG) and a first-person narration set in that scene. Right column: a shared info panel — sign video (WLASL dataset), word title, fingerspelling strip, ASL alphabet modal. Clicking a blue-underlined word in the story OR a labelled object in the scene drives the same panel. No tabs, no lessons, no quizzes — context first, vocabulary second.



THE OBSERVATION DRIVING THE WORK

Practising fingerspelling letter-by-letter — converting a 3D handshape sequence into 2D letter symbols and back — is slow and effortful. Treating the whole fingerspelled word as a single continuous gesture and mimicking the animation is faster and stickier. Fluent signers read fingerspelling holistically rather than letter-by-letter (Wilcox 1992 and subsequent work); that acquisition path is underdiscussed for late-deafened adult learners specifically — and it is reshaping how I'm designing the tool.

CURRENT STATE (2026-05-27)

6

scenarios live

76

WLASL signs wired

16

fingerspell-only entries

112

clickable word tokens